



Patch of honor

The seal of the Combined Action Program shows a South Vietnamese flag joined with the Star Spangled Banner, in reference to the program's collaboration between US Marines and South Vietnamese militiamen.

An effective model?

Ultimately, the Marine Corps declared the program a success, although the evidence is largely anecdotal. At its peak in 1970, the CAP had four Groups and more than 100 companies spread throughout I Corps. CAP platoons generally experienced lower casualty rates than units engaged in search-and-destroy operations, but they produced a higher body count relative to unit size. They also yielded positive results at lower cost. The Marine Corps boasted that no villages reverted to Viet Cong control, although that assertion might be rooted as much in Viet Cong pragmatism—why invest resources where public support is weak?—as it was in CAP platoons' ability to intimidate and persuade. Ultimately, the CAP platoons were too small, few, and unevenly distributed to have much impact on the war's outcome.

However, CAP Marines often made friends among the families in the villages to which they were assigned, and were invited to eat meals in civilians' homes. Friendships between CAP platoon members and South Vietnamese villagers who came to rely on them for security were remembered long after the war's end.